

34 GUIDES, ONE HANDBOOK

CYBER SAFETY GUY

THE COMPLETE PARENT'S GUIDE

Plain-English online safety education for parents, teachers and safeguarding professionals.

100% of subscription income is donated to **Childline (NSPCC)**

cybersafetyguy.com · Childline: 0800 1111 · childline.org.uk

If a child needs support right now: **Childline — 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk** — free, confidential, 24 hours a day.

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HOW ONLINE GROOMING ACTUALLY STARTS

It's not always scary. It's often subtle. Grooming is when someone builds a relationship with a child online to gain their trust, then manipulate, exploit or harm them. Here's what parents need to know.

1 in 5
young people contacted by a stranger online
NSPCC, 2023

35%
say someone tried to befriend them online
Ofcom, 2023

67%
of victims thought the person was a friend
NW3C, 2022

Most
grooming happens in plain sight, not the "dark web"
CEOP, 2023

The Six Stages of Online Grooming

1. **TARGETING** — Looks for someone who seems vulnerable
2. **FRIENDSHIP** — Builds a connection, gains trust
3. **TRUST & BONDING** — Makes the child feel special
4. **FILLING A NEED** — Positions themselves as the answer
5. **ISOLATION** — Slowly separates the child from others
6. **CONTROL & EXPLOITATION** — Gains power, may ask for more

Warning Signs — Your Child Might Be...

- Spending a lot of time talking to someone online.
- Getting upset when they can't go online.
- Hiding their screen or turning devices off quickly.
- Being secretive about who they're talking to.
- Becoming distant, defensive or moody.
- Receiving gifts, money, or being asked to keep secrets.
- Talking about meeting an online friend.

What Protects Kids Most

- **Open conversations**, build trust so they'll talk.
- **Healthy boundaries**, set clear rules and expectations.
- **Know their world**, understand the apps, games and trends they use.
- **Teach critical thinking**, help them spot red flags.
- **Be involved**, notice changes, ask, listen, support.

Trust + Communication + Awareness = Protection.
The goal isn't to scare kids. It's to empower them.

Conversation Starters That Work

"Who do you like talking to online?"

"What's fun about that game or app?"

"Has anyone ever made you feel weird or uncomfortable online?"

"What would you do if someone asked for a photo or a secret?"

Safety Rules That Help

- Never share personal info — name, address, school or photos.
- Don't share or send nudes — unsafe, illegal, can't be taken back.
- Don't meet online friends — people can lie about who they are.
- Tell a trusted adult if something feels wrong.
- Block and report — you don't have to respond.

Red Flags to Spot

Love-bombing | Asking for secrets | Moving to private chat | Pressuring for photos | Jealousy or control | Threats or blackmail | Offline meeting requests

What to Do If You're Worried

1. **Stay calm and listen —** reacting calmly helps them open up.
2. **Don't blame your child —** they need support, not guilt.
3. **Collect evidence —** take screenshots, save messages.
4. **Report and block —** use in-app tools and report to the platform.
5. **Get help —** contact CEOP or your local support services.

Where to Get Help

CEOP (UK): ceop.police.uk · **Childline**: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

SEXTORTION & IMAGE-BASED ABUSE

Sextortion is when someone tricks, threatens or blackmails a child using intimate images or videos. It is not your child's fault. Help and support are available. Here's what parents need to know.

1 in 7
teens are targeted by online predators before 18
Thorn, 2023

90%
of sextortion victims are threatened with image sharing
NCA, 2023

24/7
sextortion can happen at any time, anywhere
IWF, 2023

Most
victims know the person who blackmails them
NCA, 2023

How Sextortion Happens

1. **CONTACT** — Reaches out, builds a friendship
2. **TRUST** — Gains trust and attention, often flattery
3. **REQUEST** — Asks for intimate photos or videos
4. **THREAT** — Threatens to share with friends/family
5. **EXTORT** — Demands money, more images or favours

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It can happen to anyone.** Kind, smart and careful kids can still be targeted.
2. **It is not your child's fault.** The blame lies with the person doing the harm.
3. **Silence protects the blackmailer.** Talking early reduces harm and stops it escalating.

By the Numbers

79%
of sextortion victims are male
NCA, 2023

30%
of victims are under 16
Thorn, 2023

50%+
of reports started on social media platforms
IWF, 2023

Up to 18 mo.
some victims are blackmailed for
NCA, 2023

What Exists

- Privacy Controls — limit who can contact your child.
- Blocking & Reporting — block and report users or content.
- Disappearing Messages — messages can auto-delete in some apps.
- Report to Authorities — platforms can pass reports to police.

What to Change

- **Review privacy settings together.**
- **Limit who can message, comment or follow.**
- **Turn off location sharing where possible.**
- **Check app age ratings and use family tools.**

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Stay calm.** Reacting in anger or panic can make things worse.
2. **Don't pay or comply.** Paying encourages more demands. It doesn't solve it.
3. **Save the evidence.** Take screenshots. Save usernames, messages, dates.
4. **Block the person.** Block and report across all platforms and accounts.
5. **Report it.** Report to the platform and to the police.
6. **Get support.** Talk to someone you trust. You are not alone.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Emotional Harm**, Anxiety, shame and depression can follow.
- **Image Sharing**, Images may be shared with friends, school or online.
- **Ongoing Blackmail**, Demands can continue for months or years.
- **Financial Loss**, Victims may be pressured for money or gift cards.
- **Damage to Reputation**, Photos or videos can affect school, friendships and future.
- **Escalation**, Threats of self-harm or violence can be used to control.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What apps do you use to chat or game?

Do you know anyone online that you haven't met in real life?

Would you tell me if someone asked for nudes or personal pics?

Do you know you can come to me, no matter what?

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Don't delete anything.
- Take screenshots of chats, profiles and threats.
- Note dates, times and any payment requests.
- Keep the evidence safe.

Report & Seek Help

- Report to the platform immediately.
- Report to CEOP: report.ceop.police.uk.
- Call Childline: 0800 1111 (free, 24/7).
- Get help from your school if needed.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

AI "GIRLFRIENDS" / COMPANIONS

AI companions are chat apps or websites that create romantic or close relationships using artificial intelligence. They can feel real. They can feel comforting. Here's what parents need to know.

3.1M
people worldwide use AI companion apps (2024)
Sensor Tower

71%
of users are male
Business Insider

58 mins
average daily time spent
Data.ai, 2024

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's not a real person.** AI companions are designed to please and keep you engaged.
2. **It can feel real.** The connection can feel strong and even addictive.
3. **It's a fast-growing space.** New apps and features appear all the time.

By the Numbers

20%
of teens say they have used an AI companion app or site
Pew Research, 2024

$120+
average monthly spend by heavy users
Business Insider, 2024

2x
more likely to use late at night (11pm–6am)
Data.ai, 2024

200%
increase in AI companion app downloads, 2023-2024
Sensor Tower

What Exists

- Content filters — limit explicit or adult content.
- Privacy controls — control what's stored and shared.
- Block & report — block users and report issues.
- Delete data — some apps let you clear your data.

What to Change

- **Enable content filters.**
- **Review privacy settings.**
- **Limit image generation.**
- **Turn off memory if possible.**
- **Set spending limits.**

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Research the app.** Read reviews. Check age ratings and terms.
2. **Check privacy settings.** Review what data is collected and stored.
3. **Turn on safety features.** Enable filters and limit image generation.
4. **Set time and spending limits.** Use device tools or app limits.
5. **Talk about it.** Keep the conversation open and regular.
6. **Review together.** Check in often and adjust as needed.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Emotional Dependence**, May rely on AI instead of real-life relationships.
- **Inappropriate Content**, Risk of explicit or sexual content.
- **Privacy Risks**, Your child's data and chats may be stored.
- **Financial Costs**, In-app purchases and subscriptions add up.
- **Distorted Expectations**, Unrealistic ideas about love and relationships.
- **Isolation**, May withdraw from friends and family.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What do you like about the app?

How does it make you feel?

Do you feel it affects your mood or sleep?

Is there anything that worries you about it?

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Listen calmly.
- Save messages or screenshots.
- Note dates, times and what happened.
- Do not delete evidence.

Report & Seek Help

- Use the app's report and block tools.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

AI CHATBOTS & CHILDREN

AI chatbots are becoming part of everyday life for children — from homework help to entertainment and advice. They are powerful tools, but they are not designed specifically for children. This guide explains how they work, the risks, and how to approach them safely at home.

Millions
of children now use AI tools daily

No set minimum age
held consistently across platforms

Limited safeguards
built in for young users

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It can feel like a real person.** Children may trust it emotionally or socially.
2. **Confidence ≠ accuracy.** AI can sound certain while being wrong.
3. **It is not designed to protect your child.** Safeguards exist, but they are not child-focused.

By the Numbers

24/7
availability — no natural limits or stopping points

Instant
responses — encourages fast answers over critical thinking

Rapid
adoption in schools — now widely used for homework and revision

What Exists

- Content filters (limited).
- Reporting tools.
- Some child-friendly versions.

What to Change

- **Use age-appropriate versions where possible.**
- **Keep use in shared family spaces.**
- **Set the rule: no personal information shared.**

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Explain what AI is.** A tool, not a person or authority.
2. **Use it together first.** Show how it answers questions.
3. **Set clear boundaries.** No private or personal conversations.
4. **Encourage checking answers.** Use other sources for important info.
5. **Keep it visible.** Avoid unsupervised use in bedrooms.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Misinformation**, Incorrect answers presented confidently.
- **Emotional reliance**, Treating AI like a friend or support.
- **Inappropriate responses**, Filters are not perfect.
- **Privacy risks**, Personal data shared unknowingly.
- **Over-reliance**, Reducing independent thinking and effort.

The 10-Minute Conversation

"What have you used AI for so far? Can you show me?"

Do you think everything it says is always right?

What would you do if it gave a strange answer?

Would you ever share personal information with it?

Do your friends use it the same way?

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Screenshot responses.
- Save anything concerning.
- Note dates and details.

Report & Seek Help

- Use platform reporting tools.
- Speak to school if misuse involves homework.
- Seek support if your child is upset.

AI chatbots are here to stay. The goal is not to avoid them, but to help your child use them safely, critically, and with confidence.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

PIMEYES

PimEyes is a facial recognition search engine. It lets anyone upload a photo and search the internet to find other images of the same face. It can be useful, but it also comes with serious privacy and safety risks. This guide helps you keep your child safe, informed and in control.

~3 billion
faces indexed in PimEyes' search database
PimEyes / Malwarebytes, 2024

118,000
searches processed by PimEyes per day
PimEyes / Malwarebytes, 2024

1,300 photos
of a child posted online by parents on average by age 13
UK study, 2018

In 2022, privacy group Big Brother Watch filed a legal complaint against PimEyes with the UK's Information Commissioner's Office, arguing it unlawfully processes the biometric data of millions of UK citizens without consent. In 2023, PimEyes announced technical measures to block searches of children's faces, though the company has said its detection still has accuracy issues with teenagers.

What Is PimEyes?

- PimEyes is a facial recognition search engine.
- You upload a photo of a face.
- It scans the internet for matching images.
- It shows where that face appears, even on sites you didn't know about.
- It is used by the public, businesses and in some cases law enforcement.

Why Young People Should Care

- Loss of privacy — people can find images of your child without their consent.
- Online tracking — useful for stalking, harassment or following someone around the web.
- Reputation risks — old or embarrassing photos found by future employers or schools.
- Safety concerns — predators or scammers can use photos to build a profile.

The Risks Parents Should Know

- **Privacy invasion**, Anyone can search for your child's face using just one photo.
- **Stalking and harassment**, Can be used to track, locate or intimidate young people.
- **Identity misuse**, Images can be used for fake profiles, scams or grooming.
- **No control once it's indexed**, The image may still be searchable even after you delete a post.
- **False confidence**, Young people may not realise how easy it is to be found.

What Parents Can Do

1. **Talk and educate —** explain how facial recognition works.
2. **Review online presence —** Google your child's name and check what's public.
3. **Control what you share —** think before posting photos of your child.
4. **Use privacy settings —** lock down accounts, remove unnecessary photos.
5. **Teach safe habits —** be mindful of what they post and where.
6. **Use removal tools —** PimEyes offers an opt-out form.

Conversation Starters

"Do you know that people can search for your face online?"

"How would you feel if someone tracked you online?"

"What could someone do with your pictures?"

"What should you do if you see your photos online somewhere you don't like?"

Removing Your Child's Images from PimEyes

1. **Go to pimeyes.com/en/privacy —** click "Opt-out" or "Remove my photos."
2. **Fill in the form —** with the image URLs shown in the results.
3. **Submit the request —** PimEyes will review and remove the links.

Note: removal from PimEyes does not remove the image from the original website or the rest of the internet.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

THE PLATFORMS YOUR CHILD IS USING

Most children are not using just one app — they are moving between multiple platforms every day. Messaging, video, gaming, and AI tools all overlap. This guide breaks down the most common platforms and what parents need to know.

5+
Most teens use 5+ platforms regularly

—
Messaging + video apps dominate daily use

—
Risks often come from how apps connect together

The Top 10 Platforms

TikTok
Used for: Endless short videos, trends and entertainment
Watch for: Algorithm exposure, risky trends, live content

YouTube
Used for: Videos, Shorts, creators, learning
Watch for: Autoplay, inappropriate content, long sessions

Snapchat
Used for: Daily messaging, snaps and streaks
Watch for: Snap Map, disappearing messages, reply pressure

Instagram
Used for: Posts, Reels, stories, DMs
Watch for: Private messaging, comparison, body image

WhatsApp
Used for: Group chats, family, school and friends
Watch for: Large groups, bullying, unknown contacts

Roblox
Used for: Games, creating, chatting with others
Watch for: User-generated content, in-app purchases, strangers

Discord
Used for: Private servers, gaming, communities
Watch for: Hidden conversations, inappropriate content, weak moderation

BeReal
Used for: Daily real-life posts with friends
Watch for: Location clues, social pressure, oversharing

Fortnite
Used for: Gaming, building, voice chat
Watch for: Open voice chat, strangers, in-game purchases

ChatGPT & other AI tools
Used for: Homework help, answers, advice, creativity
Watch for: Misinformation, over-reliance, privacy

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's not one app — it's an ecosystem.** Children move between platforms constantly.
2. **Messaging sits underneath everything.** Most risks happen in private conversations.
3. **Features matter more than the app.** Chat, live, and sharing tools carry the risk.

What Exists

- Privacy settings on most platforms.
- Blocking and reporting tools.
- Screen time controls.

What to Change

- **Set accounts to private.**
- **Limit who can contact your child.**
- **Turn off location sharing where possible.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- Private messaging with unknown people.
- Group chat pressure and bullying.
- Exposure to inappropriate content.
- Overuse and sleep disruption.
- False sense of safety ("friends only").

The 10-Minute Conversation

Opening line: "Which apps do you use the most at the moment?"

- Which one do you spend the most time on?
- Do you message people on all of these?
- Do you know everyone you talk to?
- Has anything ever felt uncomfortable?

It's not about keeping up with every app. It's about understanding how your child uses them — and keeping communication open.

GROUP CHATS

Group chats are where young people connect, share, and laugh. They can also be where pressure, drama, and hurtful behaviour happen. Here's what parents need to know.

72%
of teens are in group chats daily
Pew Research

64%
have seen unkindness in a group chat
Ditch the Label

40%
of teens worry about what's said in chats
Internet Matters

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **Group chats move fast.** Things can escalate quickly.
2. **Your child's behaviour matters.** Kindness online is important.
3. **You don't need to read everything.** Build trust so they come to you.

By the Numbers

70%
of teens feel pressure to reply in group chats
Common Sense Media

1 in 3
teens have been left out on purpose in a group chat
Pew Research

45%
of teens have seen mean or hurtful messages
Ditch the Label

34%
of teens have seen inappropriate content
Internet Matters

What Exists

- Block & Report — block users and report bad behaviour.
- Mute — mute chats and notifications.
- Privacy Controls — limit who can add you or see you.
- Message Filters — filter spam and inappropriate content.

What to Change

- **Check who can add your child.**
- **Turn on privacy settings.**
- **Mute chats that stress them.**
- **Teach them how to block and report.**

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Know the apps.** Find out which group chats they use.
2. **Check the settings.** Review privacy and safety settings together.
3. **Talk about kindness.** Set clear expectations for how to treat others.
4. **Plan for problems.** Agree what to do if something goes wrong.
5. **Keep talking.** Check in often. Listen without judgement.
6. **Lead by example.** Show kindness and respect online.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Exclusion**, Someone may be left out on purpose.
- **Bullying**, Mean messages can hurt and last.
- **Rumours**, False stories can spread fast.
- **Inappropriate Content**, Harmful photos, videos or language.
- **Pressure**, Peers may pressure others to do things.
- **Oversharing**, Too much info can affect their safety.

The 10-Minute Conversation

Who do you chat with the most?

What's fun about your group chats?

Has anything ever upset you in a chat?

What would you do if something felt wrong?

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Stay calm and listen.
- Take screenshots if safe.
- Note the time, date and what happened.
- Keep the evidence secure.

Report & Seek Help

- Use the app's report and block tools.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Get help from school if needed.
- Contact Childline for support.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

ONLINE GAMING & VOICE CHAT

Online games are fun, social and exciting. But voice chat and online play come with risks. This guide helps you understand how to keep your child safe and confident.

84%
of 3–17 year olds play video games online
Ofcom, 2023

70%
of kids play with others online at least weekly
Ofcom, 2023

60%
of players aged 8–17 use voice chat in games
Nielsen, 2023

1 in 5
players have had a negative experience in-game
RSAC, 2023

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's not just a game.** It's social. It can shape mood, confidence and how kids connect with others.
2. **Not everyone is who they say.** People can hide their age, identity and intentions online.
3. **Balance is important.** Gaming can be healthy. Too much can affect sleep, school and wellbeing.

By the Numbers

55%
of children have talked to people they don't know while gaming
Ofcom, 2023

36%
of players have heard offensive language in voice chat
Nielsen, 2023

26%
of kids have been asked for personal information
RSAC, 2023

7 in 10
parents worry about online interactions
Parent Zone, 2023

What Exists

- Privacy & Profile Settings — control who can see and contact your child.
- Voice & Text Chat Controls — mute, block or filter players and chat.
- Friend & Party Controls — manage friend requests and party invites.
- Content & Age Ratings — games have age ratings and content info.
- Reporting & Blocking — report players and block unwanted contacts.

What to Change

- **Set accounts to private.**
- **Limit who can message or invite.**
- **Turn on chat filters if available.**
- **Disable voice chat with strangers.**
- **Review privacy and data settings (Settings > Privacy or Account > Communication).**

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Set up accounts together.** Use real info, strong passwords and privacy settings.
2. **Know their games and friends.** Ask who they play with and how they met.
3. **Talk about voice chat.** Explain kind language and what to do if someone is mean.
4. **Set time limits.** Agree on screen time and take regular breaks.
5. **Manage spending.** Use parental controls and agree on budgets.
6. **Stay involved.** Show interest. Play together. Keep the conversation going.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Strangers & Grooming**, Adults may try to befriend kids for harm.
- **Toxic Behaviour**, Swearing, insults and hate can hurt confidence.
- **Bullying & Harassment**, Targeted players may feel scared or upset.
- **Inappropriate Content**, Voice chat or game content may not be age-appropriate.
- **Scams & Phishing**, Fake giveaways or links can steal information.
- **Overspending**, In-game purchases can add up quickly.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What games are you playing right now?

Who do you play with or chat to?

Has anything online ever upset you?

What would you do if someone was mean or made you uncomfortable?

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Listen and reassure your child.
- Save screenshots or recordings.
- Note dates, times and usernames.
- Do not delete anything.

Report & Seek Help

- Report the player or content in-game.
- Use the platform's report tools.
- Block the player.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

ONLINE CHALLENGES & TRENDS

Challenges and trends spread fast online. They can be fun, silly or creative. Some can be risky or even dangerous. Here's what parents need to know.

89%
of teens say they've seen online challenges
Pew Research, 2023

1 in 5
teens say pressure to take part is common
Ofcom, 2023

46%
of parents find it hard to keep up with new trends
Internet Matters, 2023

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **Most trends are short-lived.** But the impact can be long-lasting.
2. **Not all trends are bad.** Some build skills, creativity and awareness.
3. **Peer pressure is powerful.** Kids may join in to fit in, not because they want to.

By the Numbers

64%
of teens say they've seen a challenge that worried them
Pew Research, 2023

28%
of teens say they've felt pressured to join in
Ofcom, 2023

3 in 4
trends start on short-video platforms before spreading
BBC, 2023

<24 hrs
some trends go from unknown to viral in a day
TrendWatch, 2023

What Exists

- Privacy Settings — control who can see posts and videos.
- Comment Controls — limit or block comments.
- Content Filters — limit sensitive or inappropriate content.
- Report & Block — report harmful content and block users.

What to Change

- **Set accounts to private.**
- **Limit who can comment or message.**
- **Turn on content filters where available.**
- **Check who can see your child's content.**
- **Talk about locations and personal info.**

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Stay informed.** Keep up with the apps and trends your child uses.
2. **Talk regularly.** Ask about what they're seeing and doing online.
3. **Check the facts.** Research trends together. Not everything is safe.
4. **Set boundaries.** Agree on what's okay and what's not.
5. **Encourage critical thinking.** Is it safe? Is it kind? Is it legal? Is it worth it?
6. **Know where to get help.** Save numbers and report tools. You're not alone.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Physical Injury**, Stunts or dares can cause serious harm.
- **Emotional Harm**, Shame, bullying or stress from joining in or missing out.
- **Online Pressure**, Repeated pressure can affect mental wellbeing.
- **Exposure to Harmful Content**, Some trends lead to violent, sexual or disturbing content.
- **Privacy Risks**, Sharing personal info or locations can be dangerous.
- **Long-Term Impact**, What goes online can affect future opportunities.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What trends or challenges have you seen recently?

Does anything make you feel pressured to join in?

What would you do if a challenge felt unsafe?

Who could you talk to if you were unsure?

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Stay calm. Listen and support.
- Take screenshots or save messages.
- Note dates, times and usernames.
- Do not delete evidence.

Report & Seek Help

- Report to the platform or app.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

SOCIAL MEDIA FOOTPRINT

Everything your child does online leaves a trace. That trace is their digital footprint. It can shape their future — for better or worse. Here's what parents need to know.

81%
of 13–17 year olds have posted something online others could see
Pew Research, 2023

70%
of employers screen candidates online
CareerBuilder, 2023

7 years
of content can be found about the average person online
Swayable, 2023

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's hard to erase.** Once it's online, it can stick around.
2. **It follows them.** Their footprint can affect future jobs, college and opportunities.
3. **It can put them at risk.** Too much sharing can impact safety and wellbeing.

By the Numbers

60%
of teens don't realise employers can see their online content
Kaspersky, 2023

35%
of deleted content can still be found online
Digital Citizen, 2023

46%
of teens have shared their location online
Pew Research, 2023

83%
of recruiters say online content can influence hiring decisions
CareerBuilder, 2023

What Exists

- Privacy settings — control who can see posts and info.
- Content controls — limit who can comment, message or tag.
- Location controls — turn off location sharing and check-ins.
- Data controls — manage ad preferences and data sharing.

What to Change

- **Set accounts to private.**
- **Review followers and remove anyone they don't know.**
- **Turn off location sharing.**
- **Limit past posts and who can see them.**
- **Check third-party apps and remove access.**

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Check their presence.** Search their name together. See what comes up.
2. **Review privacy settings.** Make accounts private and limit sharing.
3. **Limit what they share.** Think before posting. Less is more.
4. **Think about tags.** Control who can tag them and what gets shared.
5. **Clean up regularly.** Delete old posts and unwanted content.
6. **Keep it going.** Revisit settings and have regular chats.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Oversharing**, Too much info can put them at risk.
- **Identity theft**, Personal details can be misused.
- **Reputation damage**, Old posts can cause future problems.
- **Cyberbullying**, Hurtful content can follow them.
- **Scams and grooming**, Strangers can use info to build trust.
- **Missed opportunities**, A negative footprint can close doors.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What do you enjoy most about social media?

What do you think people can learn about you from your posts?

Is there anything you wouldn't want a future employer or teacher to see?

If something goes wrong online, will you come to me?

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Stay calm and listen.
- Take screenshots or save links.
- Note the date, time and what happened.
- Don't delete anything.

Report & Seek Help

- Report to the platform.
- Block the person.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Get help from school if needed.
- Contact Childline for support.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

ROBLOX

Roblox is an online gaming platform where kids can play games, create their own, and connect with friends. It's fun, creative and social — but it also comes with risks. Here's what parents need to know.

79.5M+
daily active users worldwide
Roblox, 2024

58%
of kids (8-12) use Roblox
DataReportal, 2024

TOP 3
app kids say they use most often
Pew Research, 2023

What Is It?

Kids play games, customise avatars, create and build, chat and hang out, join groups, and buy and trade using Robux (in-game currency).

- **Play Games** — Millions of user-created games across all genres.
- **Customise Avatar** — Design avatars and buy items to express themselves.
- **Create & Build** — Build their own games and experiences using Roblox tools.
- **Chat & Hang Out** — Chat with friends in games or private servers.
- **Join Groups** — Be part of groups and communities around shared interests.
- **Buy & Trade** — Use Robux to buy items or game passes.

Why Kids Love It

- Freedom to explore and be creative.
- Play with friends and make new ones.
- Constant new games and updates.
- Sense of achievement and rewards.
- It's engaging, fun and social.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Privacy & content restrictions — set to “13+” for more.
- Who can message me — choose Friends only.
- Who can invite me to private servers — Friends.
- Who can join me in experiences — control this setting.
- Content filters and a monthly Robux spending limit.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set privacy and content restrictions to 13+.
- Restrict messaging and private server invites to Friends.
- Enable content filters.
- Set a monthly Robux spending limit.
- Turn on Parent PIN.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Talk about who they play with and chat to.**
2. **Encourage them to think before they click or share.**
3. **Remind them: not everyone is who they say they are.**
4. **Set boundaries around screen time and game time.**
5. **Use parental controls and review settings together.**
6. **Report and block anyone who makes them feel uncomfortable.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Strangers**, Can chat and build relationships with your child.
- **Inappropriate content**, In games or user-generated content.
- **Scammers**, Try to trick kids for Robux or items.
- **Online predators**, May target kids.
- **Overspending**, On Robux and in-game items.
- **Cyberbullying**, And toxic behaviour.
- **Personal info exposure**, Public games and chats can share personal info.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What games do you like playing on Roblox?

Who do you play with?

Have you ever felt uncomfortable in a game?

What would you do if a stranger asked you to buy Robux or items?

Red Flags to Watch For

Talking to strangers or “online friends” in private.

Wanting to spend lots of Robux or real money.

Getting upset when asked to stop playing.

Secretive behaviour around Roblox.

Bullying others or being bullied.

Sharing personal information online.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk

INSTAGRAM

Instagram is a popular social media platform where kids share photos, videos, messages and stories, connect with friends and discover new content. Here's what parents need to know.

1.2B+
monthly active Instagram users worldwide
Meta, 2024

71%
of teens (13-17) use Instagram
Pew Research, 2023

53 min
average time teens spend on Instagram daily
DataReportal, 2024

What Is It?

Kids use Instagram for photos, Stories, Reels, DMs, Explore, Live, and to build followers and likes.

- **Feed** — Scroll through photos, videos and Reels from friends, creators and accounts they follow.
- **Stories** — Share moments that disappear after 24 hours, including polls, questions and links.
- **Reels** — Watch or create short, entertaining videos — highly addictive and easy to lose track of.
- **DMs** — Private messages with friends or strangers. Group chats can include people they don't know well.
- **Explore** — Discover new content, accounts and trends based on what they like and who they follow.
- **Live** — Go live to broadcast in real time and interact with viewers.
- **Followers & Likes** — Build followers, get likes and comments. Validation can affect self-esteem and confidence.

Why Kids Love It

- It's visual, fun and creative.
- Helps them stay connected with friends.
- They can express themselves.
- Builds confidence and skills.
- Feels like belonging.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Private account — only approved followers can see posts and stories.
- Who can message you — choose “People you follow” or “Don't receive requests”.
- Comments — control who can comment (Everyone / People you follow / No one).
- Hidden Words — hide offensive words and phrases in comments and messages.
- Activity Status — turn off so others can't see when your child is online.
- Sensitive Content Control — reduce sensitive content in Explore and recommended content.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set the account to private.
- Restrict who can message and comment.
- Turn on Hidden Words and Sensitive Content Control.
- Turn off Activity Status.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Talk about what they see, share and experience.**
2. **Encourage them to think before they post.**
3. **Remind them: not everything is real online.**
4. **Set boundaries around screen time.**
5. **Don't share personal info (school, location, phone number, etc.).**
6. **Report and block anything that feels wrong.**
7. **Encourage breaks and offline activities.**
8. **Stay involved and keep the conversation open.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Strangers**, Can follow, message and manipulate.
- **Inappropriate content**, Can appear in feed or Explore.
- **Pressure to look perfect**, Can hurt self-esteem.
- **Cyberbullying**, Can happen in comments or DMs.
- **Oversharing**, Can lead to privacy and safety risks.
- **Scams**, Fake accounts and phishing links exist.

The 10-Minute Conversation

Who do you follow and why?

What kind of content makes you feel good (or bad)?

Has anyone ever said or done something that made you uncomfortable?

Do you ever feel pressure to post or look a certain way?

What would you do if a stranger messaged you something weird?

Red Flags to Watch For

Sudden secrecy about Instagram use. | Getting upset after being online. | Spending much more time on Instagram. | Unusual messages or new “online friends”. | Drop in mood or self-esteem.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

SNAPCHAT

Snapchat is a photo and video messaging app where messages (Snaps) disappear after being viewed. It's fun and creative — but it also comes with risks. Here's what parents need to know.

800M+
monthly active Snapchat users worldwide
Snap Inc., 2024

75%
of 13-34 year olds in the US use Snapchat
Pew Research, 2023

30+ min
is the average time teens spend on Snapchat per day
DataReportal, 2024

What Is It?

Snapchat's key features shape how it's used and where the risks sit.

- **Snaps** — Photos or videos that disappear after being viewed (1–10 seconds by default).
- **Stories** — Snaps that last 24 hours and can be viewed by friends or everyone (public story).
- **Snap Map** — Shows your location on a map to friends who have location sharing on.
- **Chat** — Messages disappear by default after being viewed in chat.
- **Streaks** — You and a friend send Snaps back and forth for consecutive days to keep a Streak.
- **Spotlight** — Public feed of user-submitted Snaps. Anyone can view, like and share.
- **Snap Score** — A score that goes up when you send/receive Snaps. Many teens focus on getting higher.

Why Kids Love It

- It feels private and “in the moment”.
- Fun filters, Lenses and creative tools.
- Easy way to stay in touch with friends.
- Streaks create connection and routine.
- Stories and Spotlight help them express themselves.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Who can contact them — restrict to “Friends” so only accepted friends can message.
- View My Story — limit to “Friends” or “Custom” instead of “Everyone”.
- See My Location (Snap Map) — choose “Ghost Mode” or “My Friends (except...)” for more privacy.
- See Me in Quick Add — turn off so your child isn't suggested to people they don't know.
- Family Center — connect with your teen to see their privacy settings and who they've friended (not content).

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Restrict contact to Friends.
- Set View My Story to Friends or Custom.
- Turn on Ghost Mode for Snap Map.
- Turn off Quick Add suggestion.
- Check these settings together and review regularly.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Talk early and often.** Keep the conversation open and judgment-free.
2. **Know their friends.** Help them understand who's safe to talk to.
3. **Review privacy settings together.** Make them part of the process.
4. **Be aware of Snap Map.** Talk about location sharing and safety.
5. **Discuss what's not okay.** Set clear boundaries around content and behavior.
6. **Encourage them to speak up.** If something feels off, tell a trusted adult.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Disappearing doesn't mean gone.**, Screenshots, screen recordings and camera photos can save Snaps.
- **Strangers can contact your child.**, Anyone can send a Chat or view a public Story/Spotlight.
- **Location sharing can expose them.**, Snap Map can reveal where your child is — in real time.
- **Inappropriate content exists.**, Spotlight and Stories can include sensitive or explicit content.
- **Pressure & comparison.**, Streaks, Snap Score and filters can affect self-esteem.

The 10-Minute Conversation

Who do you like talking to online?

What's fun about that game/app?

Has anyone ever made you feel weird or uncomfortable online?

What would you do if someone asked for a photo or a secret?

"I'm always here if something doesn't feel right."

Red Flags to Watch For

Love-bombing or over-the-top attention. | Asking for secrets or personal photos. | Moving to private chat quickly. | Pressure for streaks or replies. | Jealousy or control. | Threats or blackmail.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

TIKTOK

TikTok is a short-form video platform where kids watch, create and share videos, follow trends and connect with a global community. Here's what parents need to know.

1 Billion+
monthly active TikTok users worldwide
DataReportal, 2024

67%
of teens (13-17) use TikTok
Pew Research, 2023

95 min
average time teens spend on TikTok daily
DataReportal, 2024

What Is It?

Kids use TikTok's For You Feed, Discover & Trends, Create & Share, Live, Follow & Connect and Inbox features.

- **For You Feed** — Endless videos personalised by TikTok's algorithm.
- **Discover & Trends** — Find and join trending sounds, challenges and viral content.
- **Create & Share** — Record, edit and share short videos with music, effects and captions.
- **Live** — Go live to interact with viewers in real time.
- **Follow & Connect** — Follow creators and friends. Like, comment, share and duet.
- **Inbox** — Message friends or others (based on settings).

Why Kids Love It

- It's fun, creative and entertaining.
- Easy way to discover new interests and talent.
- Helps them connect and feel part of a community.
- The algorithm shows content they love.
- Anyone can go viral and be seen.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Private Account — only approved followers can see videos, follow and message.
- Who Can Send Messages — choose “Friends” or “No one”.
- Comments — control who can comment (Everyone, Friends or No one).
- Duet & Stitch — choose who can duet or stitch your child's videos.
- Screen Time — set daily screen time limits and manage notifications.
- Restricted Mode — limit potentially inappropriate content.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Go to Profile > Settings and privacy > Privacy to set private account, message and comment restrictions.
- Turn on Restricted Mode and set screen time limits.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Talk about what they watch, share and post.**
2. **Encourage them to think before they post.**
3. **Set boundaries for screen time.**
4. **Don't share personal info (school, location, phone number, etc.).**
5. **Report and block anything that feels wrong.**
6. **Encourage breaks and offline activities.**
7. **Keep the conversation open and stay involved.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Inappropriate content**, Can appear in the feed.
- **Strangers**, Can contact your child through comments, DMs or Live.
- **Overuse**, Can affect sleep, mood and self-esteem.
- **Trends and challenges**, Can be risky or harmful.
- **Sharing personal info**, Can lead to privacy risks.
- **Scams**, Fake accounts and links can target teens.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What kind of videos do you like to watch on TikTok?

Who are your favourite creators and why?

Have you ever seen something that made you uncomfortable?

Do you know anyone you've talked to online?

What would you do if someone asked for personal info?

What trends or challenges are popular right now?

Red Flags to Watch For

Sudden secrecy about TikTok use.

Spending much more time on TikTok.

Getting upset after going online.

Following or talking to unknown people.

Sharing personal info or location.

Drastic mood changes or loss of interest in other activities.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

X (FORMERLY TWITTER)

X is a real-time social network where people share thoughts, news, opinions and media in short posts called “tweets” (now “posts”). It can be a great place to learn and connect — but also a place where harmful content can spread fast. Here's what parents need to know.

500M+
Monthly active users worldwide

Real-Time
News, trends and conversations happen in the moment

Public by Default
Anyone can see public posts, including your child

Built for Conversation
Connect, share and follow people with similar interests

What Is It?

- **Post & interact** — Users post short updates, reply, repost (retweet), like and quote.
- **Trending topics** — Highlight what's popular right now.
- **Follow anyone** — Including celebrities, influencers and brands.
- **Public or private posts** — Posts can be public (visible to anyone) or private (approved followers only).

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's public by default.** Unless your child has a private account, anyone can see their posts, replies and media.
2. **Anyone can reply.** Strangers can reply, quote or mention your child — even if they don't follow them.
3. **Content can be explicit.** Violent, sexual or hateful content can appear in feeds and replies, even on teen accounts.
4. **Trends move fast.** Topics can go viral quickly, including rumours or misinformation.
5. **Not just news.** X is used for memes, gaming, anime, sports, music fandoms and more.

Tip: what looks like a joke or opinion can still be hurtful or influence how your child thinks and feels.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Protect your posts — make your account private so only approved followers can see your posts.
- Limit who can reply — choose who can reply to your child's posts (everyone, people they follow, or verified followers).
- Filter sensitive content — enable “Display media that may contain sensitive content” off.
- Mute & block — mute or block accounts that post unwanted or upsetting content.
- Location — turn off precise location sharing.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Think before you post — once it's online, it can be screenshotted and shared.
- Keep personal info private — no address, school, phone number or travel plans.
- Follow accounts that add value — news, interests and positive communities.
- Report & block — use the report function for abuse, threats or illegal content.
- Log out on shared devices — always sign out when finished.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Review your child's profile and settings together.**
2. **Make the account private (if appropriate).**
3. **Adjust reply and tag settings.**
4. **Talk about what to share — and what to keep private.**
5. **Agree on screen time and bedtime boundaries.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Online abuse & harassment**, Strangers can be unkind, send threats or target your child.
- **Hate & harmful content**, Racist, sexist or extremist content can appear in feeds and replies.
- **Scams & phishing**, Fake giveaways, crypto scams and phishing links are common.
- **Pressure to engage**, Trends, likes and replies can create pressure to join in.
- **Time sink**, Endless scrolling and real-time updates can affect sleep and focus.

Remind your child: they don't have to reply. They don't have to agree. They can block, mute or walk away.

The 10-Minute Conversation

Who do you follow on X and why?

How do you know if a post or account is trustworthy?

What kind of content makes you uncomfortable?

What would you do if someone was unkind or weird with you?

Is there anything you'd hesitate to show or tell me about X?

Keep the conversation open. Curiosity builds trust.

Good to know: X's algorithm shows content based on what you engage with. The more positive content your child follows and interacts with, the better their experience will be.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

YOUTUBE

YouTube is the world's most popular video platform. It informs, entertains and inspires. It also has risks that most parents don't see coming. This guide explains how it works, what to watch for, and how to help your child use it safely.

2.7B+	13+	Free
monthly users globally	minimum age (widely bypassed)	to watch (ad-supported)

By the Numbers

1bn hrs	40+ min	8–12	70%
of YouTube watched on TVs every day	average user watches per day	YouTube is the most used platform among children this age	of young people say they've seen something on YouTube that upset them

What Is It?

YouTube is a video platform where users can watch, upload, like, comment and subscribe. It's more than entertainment — it's education, news, music, gaming, tutorials and more. It's not just a video app — it's a search engine, a social network and a streaming service, all in one.

- **Endless videos** — Millions of videos on every topic imaginable. New content uploaded every minute.
- **Search & discover** — Kids search for videos or browse topics they love. Autocomplete suggests searches.
- **Subscriptions** — Follow channels to see new videos in your Subscriptions feed.
- **Comments & chat** — Comment on videos and go live to chat (with live chat enabled).
- **YouTube Premium** — Paid membership removes ads and unlocks extra features.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **How YouTube works — the algorithm.** YouTube's algorithm decides what videos your child sees, and what comes next: you watch a video, you interact (like, comment, watch longer), the algorithm learns what you like, more similar videos are recommended, and it can become a cycle.
2. **Why it matters.** The algorithm's goal is to keep your child watching. It may recommend content that isn't suitable even if they started with something innocent.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Turn on Restricted Mode and set a daily time limit together.**
2. **Pause watch history to limit recommendations based on what they watch.**
3. **Manage search history — clear or pause search history.**
4. **Turn off comments on videos if they upload.**
5. **Choose notification preferences to reduce distractions.**

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Restricted Mode — filters out most mature content. Not 100% accurate. Can be turned off.
- Time reminders — set daily limits and get reminders when time is up.
- Pause watch history — prevents YouTube from using watch history to suggest videos.
- YouTube Kids — a separate app made for younger children with stricter controls.
- Report — report harmful videos, channels or comments.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Turn on Restricted Mode — Settings > General > Restricted Mode: ON.
- Set a daily time limit — Settings > General > Digital Wellbeing > Set daily limit.
- Pause watch history — Settings > Manage all history > Pause watch history.
- Manage search history — Settings > Privacy > Manage all history.
- Turn off comments (if they upload) — Settings > Upload defaults > Comments: OFF.
- Choose notifications — Settings > Notifications > Choose your preferences.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Inappropriate content**, Mature or harmful content can slip through.
- **Algorithm rabbit holes**, Videos can lead to extreme or risky content.
- **Misinformation**, False or misleading content can influence opinions.
- **Ads & scams**, Some ads promote scams or unsafe products.
- **Comment section**, Unkind, bullying or inappropriate comments.
- **Live streams**, Live chat can expose children to strangers or harmful content.
- **Creators acting inappropriately**, Not all creators have good intentions.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What kind of videos do you like watching?

Do you ever see things that upset you or you don't understand?

Do you know how to report or block something?

Who are your favourite creators? Why?

What would you do if something made you feel uncomfortable?

Listen more than you talk. Build trust, not fear. No judgement. No punishment for honesty.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Screenshot the content.
- Note the channel name and video details.
- Save any messages or comments.

Report & Seek Help

- Report in the app.
- Block the user or channel.
- Talk to your child.
- Contact the school if needed.

YouTube can be amazing for learning, creativity and entertainment. With the right settings, good boundaries and open conversations, it can be a positive part of your child's life.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · NSPCC: 0808 800 5000 | nspcc.org.uk · Police (if at risk): 999

YOUTUBE SHORTS

YouTube Shorts are short, vertical videos up to 60 seconds long. They're fast, fun and easy to watch – but it's important to understand how they work and how to keep your child safe. Here's what parents need to know.

70%
of 13-17 year olds watch YouTube Shorts
Ofcom, 2023

40+bn
daily views of YouTube Shorts
YouTube, 2023

60 sec
max length per Short
YouTube Help

Mobile
most Shorts are watched on phones
Think with Google

By the Numbers

63%
of kids aged 8-12 watch YouTube regularly
Ofcom, 2023

47 min
average daily time teenagers spend on YouTube
Ofcom, 2023

1 in 3
teens say they've seen content on YouTube they didn't want to see
Pew Research, 2022

70%
of teens say YouTube helps them learn new things
Pew Research, 2022

What Is It?

Short, vertical videos up to 60 seconds. Made to watch quickly on mobile. You swipe up to watch more — the feed is personalised for each user.

- **Quick & easy to watch** —
- **Endless variety** —
- **Discover new creators** —
- **Trendy & up-to-date** —
- **Gaming highlights** —
- **Music & dance** —
- **Funny moments** —
- **Creativity & inspiration** —

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **The algorithm is powerful.** It learns what they watch and shows more of the same.
2. **Not everything is suitable.** Some content can be upsetting, misleading or inappropriate.
3. **It can be addictive.** Short, fast videos can lead to hours of unintentional scrolling.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Restricted Mode — filters out potentially mature content.
- Comments — you control if comments are on or off.
- Screen Time Reminders — set reminders to take breaks.
- Digital Wellbeing — see time watched and manage usage.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Turn on Restricted Mode.
- Set daily time limits.
- Turn off comments if needed.
- Review watch & search history.
- Use a Google Account managed by you (Settings > General).

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Explore together.** Watch a few Shorts with your child. Get to know what they like.
2. **Set boundaries.** Agree on time limits and when they can watch.
3. **Check settings.** Turn on Restricted Mode and review privacy settings.
4. **Talk about content.** Discuss what's okay, what's not, and how to get help.
5. **Encourage balance.** Support offline activities, sleep and school.
6. **Stay involved.** Keep talking and check in regularly.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Inappropriate Content**, Some Shorts may show violence, adult themes or strong language.
- **Misinformation & Dangerous Trends**, False or harmful information can spread quickly.
- **Addiction & Screen Time**, Endless scrolling can affect sleep, mood and focus.
- **Scams & Clickbait**, Tricky links, fake giveaways and “get rich quick” schemes.
- **Privacy Risks**, Sharing personal info in comments or videos can be risky.
- **Pressure to Perform**, Comparing lives or seeking likes can hurt self-esteem.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What kind of Shorts do you enjoy watching?

Have you ever seen something that upset or confused you?

Do you know how to block or report?

What would you do if someone asked for your personal info?

Open conversations build trust and keep kids safe.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Stay calm. Listen to your child.
- Take screenshots or save the link.
- Note dates, times and usernames.
- Do not delete evidence.

Report & Seek Help

- Report the video or channel on YouTube.
- Use the in-app report tools.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

WHATSAPP

WhatsApp is the world's most used messaging app. It is simple, end-to-end encrypted and has almost no built-in protections for young people. Most parents use it for family chats and don't realise their child can be contacted by anyone with their number. This guide explains how it works, what the risks are, and what you can do.

2B+
Monthly active users globally

13+
Minimum age (widely bypassed)

Free
Simple, reliable, global

By the Numbers

2B+
monthly active users — the most widely used messaging app in the world

E2E
encrypted by default — strong privacy and security, but no safety oversight

No
built-in protections for teens — no age verification, no parental tools, no content controls

What Is It?

WhatsApp is a messaging app owned by Meta. It uses your phone number to connect with others, for text, voice and video calls, group chats, photo and video sharing, and status updates. Any child can enter a false date of birth — WhatsApp has no age verification, and most children who use it are under 13. Parental controls are limited because WhatsApp does not offer a parental account system.

- **Chats** — One-to-one conversations. Messages, photos, videos, voice notes and documents.
- **Groups** — Group chats with up to 1,024 members. Anyone in the group can see your child's phone number and profile.
- **Voice & Video Calls** — High quality calls over the internet, one-to-one or in groups. No recording by default.
- **Status** — 24-hour updates visible to your contacts. Similar to Stories on other platforms.
- **Disappearing Messages** — Messages that delete automatically after 24 hours, 7 days or 90 days.
- **End-to-End Encryption** — Messages and calls are encrypted. WhatsApp cannot read the content.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It uses phone numbers.** Anyone with your child's number can message them unless their privacy settings are changed.
2. **Groups are powerful.** Your child can be added to groups by anyone — even people they don't know.
3. **Very little visibility.** You cannot see your child's chats or calls. Conversation is the most important tool.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- End-to-end encryption for messages and calls.
- Two-step verification to protect account access.
- Block and report tools for unwanted contact.
- Control over who can see your profile info.
- Disappearing messages for extra privacy.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Last Seen & Online — Settings > Privacy > Last Seen & Online.
- Profile Photo — Settings > Privacy > Profile Photo.
- About — Settings > Privacy > About.
- Groups — Settings > Privacy > Groups (control who can add them).
- Blocked Contacts — Settings > Privacy > Blocked Contacts.
- Disappearing Messages — open chat > Contact name > Disappearing Messages (set to 24hr or 90 days).

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Ask open questions about who they chat to.**
2. **Explain why some people pretend to be someone they are not.**
3. **Talk about what not to share (location, school, routines, photos).**
4. **Agree on what to do if something feels wrong.**
5. **Remind them they can always come to you.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Stranger contact**, Anyone with your child's number can message them. Many adults pretend to be teens.
- **Group risks**, Your child can be added to groups with strangers. Content and conversations vary widely.
- **Scams and phishing**, Links and messages can lead to scams, fake giveaways and phishing attacks.
- **Oversharing**, Location, school, routines and personal information can be shared easily.
- **Forwarding and screenshots**, Content can be forwarded, saved or screenshotted before it disappears.
- **Off-platform grooming**, WhatsApp is frequently used to move conversations away from safer platforms.

Where to Get Help

Childline: available 24/7 at 0800 1111 or childline.org.uk

The 10-Minute Conversation

Ask open questions about who they chat to.

Explain why some people pretend to be someone they are not.

Talk about what not to share (location, school, routines, photos).

Agree on what to do if something feels wrong.

Remind them they can always come to you.

Sit down with your child and ask them to show you how they use WhatsApp, then listen without judging. It builds trust and opens the door.

DISCORD

Discord started as a chat app for gamers. Today it is used by millions of young people for gaming, homework, hobbies and friendship groups. It is real-time, invite-based and built around communities called servers — which can be amazing, but also risky. This guide explains how it works, what the dangers are, and how to keep your child safer.

150M+
Monthly active users globally

13+
Minimum age to sign up

Free
Parental controls via Family Centre

By the Numbers

150M+
monthly active users globally — Discord is huge and still growing

Any age
can sign up — no age verification, only self-reported dates of birth

Servers
is where most harm happens — not just DMs

What Is It?

Discord is a communication platform built around servers — online communities where people text, voice call and video chat. It is used for gaming, schools, study groups, hobbies and friendships. Anyone can create a Discord account with no age verification, and many adults pretending to be teens are on Discord.

- **Servers** — Communities organised by topics. Anyone can create a server and invite others to join.
- **Channels** — Servers are split into text and voice channels for different topics and conversations.
- **Voice & Video** — Users can voice call or video chat in real time. Screen sharing is also available.
- **Direct Messages** — Private one-to-one or group chats outside of servers. Strangers can message your child.
- **Roles & Permissions** — Server owners can give roles that unlock access to certain channels and features.
- **Bots & Integrations** — Third-party tools can add extra features — some are helpful, some are not.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **Invitation is the key.** Your child can join almost any server using an invite link. These links can be shared anywhere — games, YouTube, TikTok, friends.
2. **Real-time, always on.** Conversations happen in real time. Once something is said or seen, it can be screenshot, saved and shared elsewhere.
3. **Anonymity is easy.** Usernames and custom avatars make it easy for people to hide who they really are.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Go to Settings.** On your child's account, click the gear icon (User Settings).
2. **Open Family Centre.** Select “Family Centre” from the menu.
3. **Invite your teen.** Follow the steps to send an invite link to your teen.
4. **They accept.** Your teen needs to accept the invite on their account.
5. **You're connected.** Once connected, you can manage settings and see activity.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Explicit Content Filter — scans and blocks explicit images in DMs, on by default for all users.
- DM Safety Settings — limits who can message your child. Set to “Friends” by default.
- Server Privacy — servers are private by default; your child must accept an invite to join.
- Safe Direct Messaging — automatically scans DMs for harmful links and sends warnings.
- Report & Block — easy reporting and blocking tools; reports go to Discord's safety team 24/7.
- Quiet Hours — mute notifications at certain times to support better sleep.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set up Family Centre: Settings > User Settings > Family Centre, then invite your teen to connect accounts.
- Once connected, manage Account Settings, review the Weekly Activity Report, set Screen Time Limits, and adjust Content & Privacy filters.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Stranger contact**, Adults can join servers and befriend children.
- **Grooming and manipulation**, Offenders build trust in servers then move chats to DMs or other apps.
- **Explicit content (18+)**, Servers can contain violence, hate, self-harm or sexual content.
- **Scams and phishing**, Fake links, giveaways and “nitro” scams are common in servers.
- **Oversharing**, Location, school, routines and personal info shared in chats can be dangerous.

The 10-Minute Conversation

“What servers are you in?”

“What do you like about Discord?”

Talk about trust: not everyone is who they say they are online.

Explain what to do if something feels wrong.

Agree on time limits and downtime.

Remind them they can always come to you.

Sit down with your child and ask them to show you how they use Discord, focusing on understanding their world rather than judging it.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Save evidence of the content, messages or profile.

Report & Seek Help

- Use the in-app report tool. Choose the right category and include details.
- Contact CEOP (ceop.police.uk) or Childline for support. For serious concerns, contact police.

LIVESTREAMING (TIKTOK LIVE, TWITCH, YOUTUBE LIVE)

Livestreaming lets people broadcast video in real time to an audience. It can be fun, creative and social – but it also comes with risks. Here's what parents need to know.

70%
of 13-17 year olds have watched a live stream
Ofcom, 2023

1 in 3
teens have livestreamed or want to
Pew Research, 2022

45%
of parents worry live streaming exposes kids to inappropriate content or contact
NCSA, 2023

By the Numbers

56%
of teens say they watch live streams weekly
Pew Research, 2022

1 in 4
teens have chatted with someone they don't know during a live stream
NCSA, 2023

33%
of teen streamers have received unwanted invites or messages
Internet Matters, 2023

2+ hrs
average time tweens/teens spend watching streams daily
Common Sense Media, 2023

What Is It?

Streamers go live from an app or device. Viewers watch and interact in the chat.

- **TikTok LIVE** — Short-form video and live. Easy to go live from mobile.
- **Twitch** — Popular for gaming, creative and "Just Chatting" streams.
- **YouTube Live** — Livestream on your channel to subscribers and the public.
- **Other Apps** — Instagram Live, Kick, Facebook Live and more. Check privacy settings.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **Live is live.** There is no edit button.
2. **Anyone can watch, message or share.** Even if accounts are private.
3. **Your child's safety comes first.** Boundaries, settings and support make a big difference.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Privacy Settings — choose who can watch your live streams.
- Chat Controls — slow mode, subscriber-only chat, blocked words.
- Moderators — trusted people can help manage chat.
- Block & Report — block users and report abuse or inappropriate behaviour.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Go live to Friends or Subscribers only.
- Turn on chat filters and block keywords.
- Require approval for guests/hosts.
- Review who can send gifts or donations.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Set your goals.** Why are you streaming? What are your boundaries?
2. **Check your privacy.** Choose who can watch and comment.
3. **Set up chat controls.** Use filters, slow mode or sub-only chat.
4. **Plan your space.** Keep personal info, location and screens private.
5. **Take breaks.** Schedule offline time and step away.
6. **Review and adjust.** Check settings and what's working. Get help if needed.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Inappropriate Comments**, Harmful, rude or sexual messages in chat.
- **Strangers & Predators**, Adults may target kids in live chats.
- **Oversharing**, Sharing too much can put safety at risk.
- **Pressure to Perform**, Feeling pressured to stream more or accept gifts.
- **Scams & Exploitation**, Fake giveaways, links and requests for money.
- **Content Going Viral**, Clips can be saved and shared without consent.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What do you enjoy most about going live?

Who usually joins your chat? Anyone you don't know?

What boundaries do you want to set?

What would you do if something makes you uncomfortable?

Open talks build trust. Trust keeps kids safe.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- End the stream if it feels unsafe.
- Block the user.
- Save screenshots or recordings.
- Note the time, username and what happened.

Report & Seek Help

- Report the user on the platform.
- Use in-app report tools.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

BEREAL

BeReal is a social media app built around sharing one unfiltered photo a day. It encourages users to post a real-time snapshot of their life with no editing. It feels safer than other platforms — but there are still important risks parents should understand.

20M+	13+	Focus
daily users globally	minimum age (not enforced)	on “authentic” sharing

By the Numbers

1	2 min	Late
post per day — designed to reduce overuse	window — encourages instant, unedited sharing	posts are labelled — creates pressure to post on time

What Is It?

BeReal is a photo-sharing app where users post one unedited photo per day at a random time.

- **Daily notification** — Everyone posts at the same random time.
- **Dual camera** — Front and back camera used at once.
- **No filters** — Photos are unedited and “real”.
- **Friends-only feed** — Content mainly from people you know.
- **Discovery (optional)** — Public posts from strangers if enabled.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **“Real” does not mean risk-free.** Posting real life can expose more than intended.
2. **Location clues are easy to miss.** Backgrounds can reveal where your child is.
3. **Social pressure still exists.** Daily posting can feel compulsory.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Friends-only posting by default.
- Optional private account.
- Ability to disable public discovery.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Turn Discovery OFF (no public posts).
- Limit friends to people they know in real life.
- Disable location sharing (if enabled).

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Set account to private.** Ensure only approved friends can see posts.
2. **Review friend list together.** Remove unknown or unnecessary contacts.
3. **Turn off Discovery.** Prevent posts being visible to strangers.
4. **Talk about surroundings.** Avoid sharing location clues (school, home).
5. **Normalise skipping a post.** Missing a day is okay.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Location exposure**, Backgrounds reveal home, school, routines and places you visit.
- **Peer pressure**, Pressure to post daily and "fit in".
- **Unintended sharing**, Photos capture more than expected in the moment.
- **Stranger visibility**, If Discovery is enabled, anyone can see your posts.
- **False sense of safety**, "Friends only" can still include the wrong people.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What do you usually post on BeReal? Can I see one?

Do you know everyone on your friends list?

Have you ever posted something and then regretted it?

Do you feel pressure to post every day?

What would you do if someone you didn't know added you?

Curiosity before concern. No pressure, no judgement. Help them think before they post.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Screenshot posts or interactions.
- Save anything concerning.

Report & Seek Help

- Remove/block users.
- Report through the app.
- Speak to school if peers are involved.

BeReal is designed to be simpler and more authentic than other platforms. That helps — but it doesn't remove the need for awareness, boundaries, and open conversations.

OMOGGLE

Omoggle is an AI-powered video chat platform where users are randomly paired and rated on their appearance in "mog battles". It blends webcam chat with AI face scoring, leaderboards and ELO rankings — fuelling a growing "looksmaxxing" culture. It may seem like fun, but the risks to self-esteem, privacy and mental health are real.

AI-Rated
webcam battles — AI gives attractiveness scores (1–10)

Looksmaxxing
culture — improving looks via grooming, fitness, surgery, filters

Streamer-driven
virality — huge on Twitch, TikTok and Kick

ELO Rankings
compete, climb leaderboards, chase validation

How Omoggle Works

1. **Random Match —** you're paired with a random stranger on webcam.
2. **AI Face Scan —** AI analyses your face and gives a score (1–10).
3. **Mog Battle —** you both see each other and compete.
4. **ELO & Rank —** win rounds, earn points, climb the leaderboards.
5. **Go Live —** many users stream their battles for clout.

Key terms: MOGGING (out-appearing someone); LOOKSMAXXING (maximising appearance through grooming, fitness, surgery, filters); PSL (the "Pretty Scale", a 1–10 rating); ELO (a ranking system matching similar scores).

Why Teens Are Drawn to Omoggle

- Instant validation and attention.
- Competitive leaderboards and ranks.
- Thrill of random interaction.
- Livestream fame and community.
- Belonging in looksmaxxing culture.

The Hidden Risks

- **AI scores are not accurate**, and can be biased.
- **Constant comparison**, damages self-esteem and body image.
- **Cyberbullying, roasting and public humiliation**
- **Risk of exposure**, your face can be recorded, clipped and shared.
- **Groomers**, can use webcam chats to build trust and exploit.

What Parents Can Do

1. **Start the conversation —** talk early, talk often.
2. **Validate feelings —** listen without judgement.
3. **Build real confidence —** praise effort and values, not just looks.
4. **Encourage balance —** support offline hobbies and friendships.
5. **Stay informed together —** explore the platform, make safety a team sport.

Spot the Red Flags

- Chasing higher scores
- Feeling not good enough
- Obsessing over appearance
- Withdrawing from friends
- Lying about screen time
- Being secretive

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

CHAT HOUR

Chat Hour is an online chat community and social networking app with public chat rooms, private messaging, user profiles and interest-based communities. It has been around since 1999 and connects people from all over the world.

Est. 1999
Over 20 years of connecting people online

100K+
Android downloads
Google Play

16+/17+
age rating — mature content and interactions may be present
Google Play / App Store

Chat rooms
& messaging — public chat rooms, private messages and friend lists

What Is It?

Chat Hour is not just about one-to-one messaging — public chat rooms are the heart of the app.

- **Public Chat Rooms** — Join thousands of chat rooms on all kinds of topics.
- **User Profiles** — Create a profile, add photos, about me and interests.
- **Private Messaging** — Send direct messages to other members.
- **Friend Lists** — Add friends, follow users and keep in touch.
- **Interest-Based Chatting** — Find rooms and people who share your interests.
- **Filters** — Search and filter by location, age and gender.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **Most interactions are with strangers.** Even in “teen” or “17+” rooms, adults can join and chat.
2. **Profiles can be fake.** Photos, age, location and interests can all be made up.
3. **Private messaging increases risk.** The more personal the conversation, the higher the potential for danger.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Block Users — block anyone who makes you uncomfortable.
- Report Users — report inappropriate behavior or content.
- Profile Controls — control who can message you and view your profile.
- Chat Room Moderation — rooms have moderators, but not all content is filtered.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Encourage your child to use public chat rooms, not private chats.
- Remind them to never share personal information or photos.
- Use strong privacy settings and block/report when needed.
- Encourage them to leave any chat that feels uncomfortable.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Talk regularly about online activity and online friends.**
2. **Encourage your child to use public chat rooms, not private chats.**
3. **Remind them to never share personal information or photos.**
4. **Use strong privacy settings and block/report when needed.**
5. **Encourage them to leave any chat that feels uncomfortable.**
6. **Know that it's okay to talk to you about anything.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Adult Users**, Many adults use Chat Hour. Not everyone is who they say they are.
- **Private Messages From Strangers**, Private chats can move quickly and are harder to monitor.
- **Catfishing & Fake Profiles**, People may lie about their age, looks, identity or intentions.
- **Scams & Grooming Risks**, Some users may build trust to manipulate, exploit or harm young people.
- **Sexual Conversations**, Mature or inappropriate language and themes can appear in chats.
- **Oversharing Personal Information**, Sharing location, school, photos or social media can put you at risk.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What chat rooms do you like to use on Chat Hour?

Do you know the people you are messaging?

Has anyone ever said or done something that made you uncomfortable?

What would you do if someone asked you to move the chat to another app or sent you something inappropriate?

Can we look at your privacy settings together?

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

WIZZ

Wizz is a social discovery app that helps people meet and chat with new people. Users swipe through profiles, send chat requests and build connections. It's designed for “friend making”, but many users treat it like a dating app. It can be fun and positive — but it also comes with real risks. Here's what parents need to know.

15M+
downloads worldwide
App Store & Google Play

Swipe & chat
design — swipe through profiles and send chat requests
wizzapp.com

Age-verified
profiles — uses facial age estimation to keep users in age groups

Stranger messaging
risks — messaging with strangers always carries risk

What Is It?

Wizz is for 16+ in the UK and many other countries — always check the age rating in your app store.

- **Swipe Profiles** — Browse people nearby or in your chosen area.
- **Chat Requests** — Send a request and chat when accepted.
- **Public Profiles** — Users share photos, age, bio and interests.
- **Find Friends** — Designed to help you meet and make friends.
- **Boosts & Perks** — Premium features and boosts increase visibility.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **Most interactions are with strangers.** Even if someone seems friendly, you don't really know who they are.
2. **Profiles can be misleading.** Photos, age, location and interests can be fake or exaggerated.
3. **Private conversations increase risk.** The more personal the conversation, the greater the potential for harm.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Age Verification — facial age estimation helps keep users in age-appropriate groups.
- Profile Verification — users can verify their profile to build trust.
- Report & Block — report inappropriate users and block anyone you don't want to talk to.
- Content Moderation — Wizz monitors content and takes action against rule breakers.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Stay involved, build trust and keep the conversation open and ongoing.
- Talk regularly about online friendships and relationships.
- Set clear boundaries around apps and screen time.
- Encourage them to keep chats on the app and not share personal info.
- Never share photos of themselves with someone they just met.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Talk regularly about online friendships and relationships.**
2. **Set clear boundaries around apps and screen time.**
3. **Encourage them to keep chats on the app and not share personal info.**
4. **Never share photos of themselves with someone they just met.**
5. **Use strong privacy settings and block/report when needed.**
6. **Remind them that they can always come to you.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Contact With Strangers**, Anyone can create a profile and message your child. Not everyone is who they say they are.
- **Catfishing & Fake Profiles**, People may use fake photos, ages or bios to trick or manipulate others.
- **Sexual Messages & Content (18+)**, Some users may send sexual messages or ask for photos.
- **Grooming & Manipulation**, Predators can build trust over time to control or exploit young people.
- **Sextortion & Blackmail**, Explicit photos or videos can be used to threaten or blackmail.
- **Pressure To Move Off-App**, Users may push to move the chat to Snapchat, Instagram or other apps where it's harder to see or control.
- **Appearance Pressure**, Constant swiping and comparison can affect self-esteem and body image.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What do you like most about Wizz?

Who do you usually talk to on the app?

Do you know everyone you chat with?

Has anyone said or done something that made you uncomfortable?

What would you do if someone asked you for photos or to move to another app?

Can we look at your privacy settings together?

Red Flags to Watch For

Spending a lot of time on Wizz or being secretive.
New “online friends” they won't tell you about.
Moving conversations off the app quickly.
Receiving compliments, gifts or money offers.
Asking for or sending nudes or inappropriate photos.
Talking about meeting in person.
Mood changes after using the app.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

KIK

Kik is a messaging app that allows users to chat using usernames rather than phone numbers. While Kik is now intended for adults aged 18+, parents may still encounter references to it because it was historically popular with teenagers. Understanding how it works helps families discuss online safety confidently.

18+
Minimum age for new accounts

UK checks
Age verification required for UK users

Username-based
Users do not need to share a phone number

Group chats
Can include people you do not know

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **Messages aren't limited to friends.** Users can receive messages from people they have never met.
2. **Usernames can create a false sense of privacy.** Not sharing a phone number does not remove all risks.
3. **Most chats are harmless.** The biggest concern is unwanted contact from strangers.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Block & Report — block unwanted users and report concerns.
- Chat Controls — manage conversations and contacts.
- Privacy Options — limit unwanted interactions.
- Group Management — leave or manage group chats.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Review privacy settings together.
- Block unknown contacts immediately.
- Check group memberships regularly.
- Avoid usernames containing personal information.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Review privacy settings together.**
2. **Use a username that reveals as little as possible.**
3. **Only chat with people you know offline.**
4. **Leave groups that feel uncomfortable.**
5. **Block and report unwanted messages.**
6. **Talk openly about online experiences.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Strangers making contact**, Some users actively seek conversations with young people.
- **Inappropriate messages**, Unwanted content can sometimes appear.
- **Fake profiles**, Not everyone online is who they claim to be.
- **Age misrepresentation**, Some users may not be the age they claim.
- **Oversharing**, Personal information can spread quickly.
- **Scams**, Fraudulent links and requests do occur.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What do you enjoy most about using Kik?

Who do you usually chat with?

How do you decide who to add?

What would you do if a stranger messaged you?

Do you know how to block someone?

Open conversations build confidence. Children are more likely to ask for help when they know they won't get into trouble.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Save screenshots.
- Record usernames.
- Stop replying if a conversation feels unsafe.

Report & Seek Help

- Use Kik's reporting tools.
- Block the user immediately.
- Speak to a trusted adult.
- Contact police if there is immediate risk.

CHARACTER.AI

Character.AI (often called c.ai) is an AI chat platform where users can talk with millions of user-created AI characters. You can create your own characters, roleplay conversations, or chat with AI companions on a wide range of topics. It can be fun, creative and supportive — but it also carries real risks. Here's what parents need to know.

AI Chats
Chat with AI characters on any topic

Millions
of user-created characters, from creators worldwide

Text & Voice
Chat with characters using text or voice

Mobile & Web
Use on the app or at character.ai in your browser

What Is It?

Character.AI has age guidance of 13+ with parental guidance. Some content may not be appropriate for all ages.

- **Chat with AI characters** — On any topic you like.
- **Create your own characters** — Bring ideas to life.
- **Roleplay and storytelling** — In different worlds.
- **Fictional companions** — For fun and conversation.
- **AI tutors and helpers** — For homework, advice and learning.
- **Voice chat** — With selected characters.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **The AI can feel very real.** Conversations feel human and personal, which can create strong emotional connections.
2. **Characters are not real people.** AI can't truly understand or feel. It generates responses based on patterns, not emotions.
3. **Conversations can become intense.** Some chats can become very emotional, romantic or sensitive over time.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Reporting Tools — report inappropriate content, characters or users.
- Block Users — block users you don't want to interact with.
- Account Controls — manage privacy settings and content preferences.
- Content Filtering — filters help reduce sensitive or explicit content.
- Community Guidelines — rules are in place to keep the community safer.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Keep conversations balanced with real life.
- Don't share personal information with AI or strangers.
- Remember: AI can make mistakes or say harmful things.
- Encourage offline hobbies, friends and activities.
- Talk about how AI works and its limitations.
- Review settings and safety features together.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Keep conversations balanced with real life.**
2. **Don't share personal information with AI or strangers.**
3. **Remember: AI can make mistakes or say harmful things.**
4. **Encourage offline hobbies, friends and activities.**
5. **Talk about how AI works and its limitations.**
6. **Review settings and safety features together.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Emotional dependency**, Users may rely on AI for comfort instead of real-life relationships.
- **Inappropriate conversations**, Some characters or users may engage in mature or sexual content.
- **AI giving incorrect advice**, AI is not always accurate and can give harmful or misleading information.
- **Isolation**, Too much time on the app can reduce real-world social interaction.
- **Exposure to mature themes**, Some content may not be suitable for younger users.
- **Sharing personal information**, Users may share things they shouldn't with an AI (or in public rooms).

The 10-Minute Conversation

Which characters do you like to chat with most?

What do you enjoy talking to them about?

Do you ever feel attached to an AI character?

How do you know the difference between AI and real relationships?

Have you ever had a conversation that made you uncomfortable?

What would you do if a character said something inappropriate?

Red Flags to Watch For

Preferring AI over friends and family.

Distress or anger when unable to access the app.

Secretive use or hiding conversations.

Believing the AI is conscious or “in love” with them.

Excessive time spent chatting instead of other activities.

Withdrawal from offline activities or hobbies.

The hidden risk: “The AI always responds.” Unlike real friendships, AI companions are available 24/7 and never get tired. This can create a powerful emotional pull and make it hard to step away.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

LOCKET WIDGET

Locket is a photo-sharing widget that lives on your home screen. You and your child's friends can send pictures that appear instantly in the widget. It's fun, personal and constant — so it's important to understand how it works and how to keep it safe.

Teens love it

Millions of young people use Locket to stay close with their friends

Real-time sharing

Photos appear instantly on each other's home screens

Private by design

Content is only shared with people you choose

Built for connection

Simple, positive moments shared throughout the day

What Is It?

Locket is a free app that puts a live photo feed from your friends on your home screen. You send a photo — it appears on their widget. They send one — it appears on yours. It's designed for close friends and real-life connections. Photos cannot be seen outside your friends list.

- **Add friends** — You and your child add each other (usually by link or QR code).
- **Send a photo** — They take a photo in the app and send it to their friends.
- **It appears instantly** — The photo shows up on their friends' widget right away.
- **Reply with your own** — Friends can keep sharing moments throughout the day.

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It feels personal and constant.** Photos appear on a widget your child sees every time they unlock their phone.
2. **It's easy to share too much.** Photos may include location clues, routines or things better kept private.
3. **Friends list = audience.** Make sure your child only adds people they know and trust in real life.
4. **It's not moderated.** Locket doesn't filter photos. What's shared is up to your child and their friends.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Photo Approval — turn on to approve photos before they appear on the widget.
- Save Incoming Photos — keep OFF so others can't save photos to their camera roll.
- Hide Locket from Friends — use if they want a break or more privacy.
- Manage Friends — only add people they know and trust in real life.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Turn on Photo Approval.
- Keep Save Incoming Photos OFF.
- Manage friends list regularly.
- Take breaks — it's OK to pause or take a break from the app.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Download Locket and explore it together.**
2. **Review the settings.** Photo approval, save incoming photos, hide from friends.
3. **Talk about what's safe to share.**
4. **Check who they've added as friends.**
5. **Revisit regularly.** Settings and conversations.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Location clues**, Backgrounds, landmarks or routines can reveal where they are.
- **Over-sharing**, Too much personal info can be pieced together over time.
- **Wrong friends**, Adding someone they don't really know could lead to uncomfortable situations.
- **Screenshots**, Others can still screenshot photos and share them elsewhere.

The 10-Minute Conversation

Who are you sharing with on Locket?

What kind of photos are OK to send — and not OK?

Could someone guess where you are or what you're doing from your photos?

Would you send this photo if a teacher, coach or future employer saw it?

How would you feel if someone screen-shotted your photo?

Keep the conversation open, calm and judgment-free. It helps them make safer choices.

Remind your child: think before you snap. Once it's sent, you can't control what happens next.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk · The Mix: 0808 808 4994 | themix.org.uk · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org

ANDROID PARENTAL CONTROLS (GOOGLE FAMILY LINK)

Google Family Link is a free app that gives parents genuine control over what their child does on an Android phone or tablet. It covers screen time, app access, content, location and purchases — all managed from your own phone. Here's everything you need to set it up and get it right.

Free
Google Family Link — no subscription needed

72%
of UK smartphones run Android
Statcounter, 2024

6
key risk areas Family Link can help control

0
default limits — nothing is set without you

What Family Link Controls

- **Screen Time**, Set daily limits per app, total daily caps, bedtime locks and a School Time mode with stricter controls during school hours while still allowing educational apps.
- **App Control**, See every installed app. Approve or block anything before it downloads. Nothing arrives without your knowledge.
- **Content Filters**, Set Google Play content ratings, turn on SafeSearch and control what Chrome can access. Block other browsers entirely.
- **Location Sharing**, See your child's real-time location on a map. Manage which apps can access their location in the device settings.
- **Purchase Control**, Require your approval for every in-app purchase. Set monthly spending limits. Remove saved payment cards.
- **Activity Reports**, Weekly reports show what apps were used and for how long. A useful starting point for conversations, not just rules.

Without Family Link — Risks

- No default screen time limits — children self-regulate online, which rarely works.
- Any app can be downloaded from Google Play, including age-inappropriate ones.
- Explicit content is searchable without SafeSearch being enabled.
- In-app purchases can be made using any saved payment card, without approval.
- Social apps access location data silently, without you knowing.
- No visibility into what your child is doing or how long they spend online.

With Family Link — What You Can Do

- Set daily screen time limits and automatic bedtime locks from your phone.
- Approve or block every app before it downloads — nothing arrives unannounced.
- Turn on SafeSearch and restrict content ratings in Google Play automatically.
- Require your approval for every purchase and remove saved payment cards.
- See your child's real-time location and control which apps can access it.
- Receive weekly usage reports to stay informed without constant monitoring.

Setting It Up — Step by Step

1. **Download —** get Google Family Link from the App Store or Google Play on your phone. This is the parent app — everything is managed from your side.
2. **Link —** open Family Link, tap Get Started and follow the prompts to link your child's Google account. Under-13s get a supervised account created automatically.
3. **Accept —** on your child's Android, sign in to their Google account when prompted and accept the supervision request. The device confirms it is now supervised.
4. **Configure —** your child's device now appears in Family Link. Set screen time, block unapproved apps, enable location and purchase approval.

Tip: If your child already has an existing Google account, you can add supervision without creating a new one. On their device go to Settings → Google → Parental Controls to link their existing account to Family Link.

Key Settings — What Parents Can Control

SCREEN TIME & APP LIMITS

- Family Link → child's name → Daily Activity → set app-time limits.
- Daily Limit → set total daily cap across all apps.
- Bedtime → schedule hours when device locks (different for school/weekend).
- School Time → stricter limits during school hours, educational apps still permitted.
- Manage Apps → block unapproved apps or mark as Always Allowed.
- On Android 16+, many controls are also accessible directly under Settings → Digital Wellbeing on the child's device.

CONTENT CONTROLS

- Google Play → Parental Controls → set content rating (9+, 12+, 16+).
- Family Link → Google Search → turn on SafeSearch.
- Manage → Chrome → set to approved sites only or block entirely.
- Block non-Chrome browsers (Firefox, Brave etc) in Apps — content filters don't apply to other browsers.

IN-APP PURCHASES

- Manage → Google Play → Purchases → Require approval for all purchases.
- Child's device → Play Store → Settings → Purchase Authentication → Always.
- Remove saved payment cards from child's Google account.

ACTIVITY REPORTS

- Weekly reports sent automatically to your phone via Family Link.
- Shows time spent per app — useful for conversations, not just enforcement.
- View anytime in Family Link → child's name → Daily Activity.

LOCATION SHARING

- Family Link → child's name → Location → toggle on.
- Your child receives a notification — this transparency is intentional.
- Child's device → Settings → Location → App Permissions → set social apps to Denied.

WHO THEY CAN TALK TO

- Manage → App Permissions → Contacts → revoke access for unapproved apps.
- Android has no built-in comms limits — control which messaging apps are installed.
- For Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok, Discord and WhatsApp — see the CSG platform guides earlier in this handbook.

Conversation Starters

Which apps do you use most? Show me what they do.

Have you ever seen anything online that made you uncomfortable?

Do you know what to do if a stranger messages you?

Is there anything you wish you hadn't seen?

If something felt wrong online, would you tell me right away?

Red Flags to Watch For

Hiding the screen or closing apps quickly when you walk past.

Becoming upset, anxious or withdrawn after being on their phone.

Receiving messages at unusual hours or from unknown contacts.

New “online friends” they won't tell you about.

Unexplained charges on a linked bank account or payment card.

Spending much more time on their phone than usual, especially at night.

Quick Check — Things to Do Right Now

- Download Google Family Link and link your child's Android account.
- Set a daily screen time limit, bedtime lock and School Time mode.
- Turn on SafeSearch and set a content rating in Google Play.
- Enable location sharing and set social apps to Location Denied.
- Turn on purchase approval and remove saved payment cards.
- Block any non-Chrome browsers from the Apps section.

Family Link is a tool, not a solution. The most important thing is keeping the conversation open. If your child comes to you with something worrying, your reaction in that moment decides whether they come to you again.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk — free, confidential support for young people 24/7 · CEOP (Child Exploitation): ceop.police.uk — report online grooming or sexual exploitation · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org — guides and tools for parents on online safety

IPHONE & IPAD PARENTAL CONTROLS (IOS SCREEN TIME)

Screen Time is Apple's built-in parental controls system — no separate app needed. It gives parents genuine control over screen time, app access, explicit content, communications and purchases, all secured behind a passcode your child cannot guess. Here's how to set it up properly and what every setting actually does.

Built In	52%	1	0
no download needed — already on every iPhone and iPad	of UK teens have an iPhone Statcounter, 2024	passcode locks all settings — your child cannot turn it off	default limits — Screen Time must be turned on manually

What Screen Time Controls

- **Downtime**, Schedule hours when only approved apps work — great for bedtime and school. Your child cannot override it without the Screen Time passcode.
- **App Limits**, Set daily limits per app or per category (Social Networking, Games, Entertainment). The app greys out when time is up.
- **Content & Privacy**, Restrict explicit content, set age ratings, control web browsing, block adult websites and limit what Siri can return.
- **Communication Limits**, Control who your child can call, message and FaceTime — during screen time and during Downtime separately.
- **Location & Family Sharing**, Share location between family members via Find My. Control which apps can access location data at device level.
- **Purchase Controls**, Block in-app purchases entirely or require the Apple ID password for every download, including free apps.

Without Screen Time — Risks

- No time limits — a child can spend unlimited hours on any app, including social media at 2am.
- Any app rated 17+ can be downloaded from the App Store without restriction.
- Safari can access adult websites without any content filter applied.
- In-app purchases can be completed using any saved payment method without a password.
- Strangers can contact your child via iMessage, FaceTime and third-party apps without restriction.
- No visibility into how long your child spends on each app or access.

With Screen Time — What You Can Do

- Set Downtime hours so devices automatically lock at bedtime and during school.
- Restrict app downloads by age rating and require your Apple ID for every purchase.
- Limit web browsing to approved sites only, or block adult content automatically.
- Block in-app purchases entirely, or require a password for every transaction.
- Limit who can call or message your child — Contacts Only or specific people.
- Review weekly Screen Time reports showing exactly which apps were used and for how long.

Setting It Up — Step by Step

1. **Enable Screen Time —** Settings → Screen Time → Turn On Screen Time → tap "This is My Child's iPhone". If setting up on your own phone first, choose "This is My iPhone" then use Family Sharing.
2. **Set a Screen Time passcode —** when prompted, set a Screen Time passcode. Make it different from the device passcode. This prevents your child from turning off Screen Time or changing their limits.
3. **Schedule Downtime —** Downtime → toggle on → set start and end time. Only apps in Always Allowed will work during Downtime. Phone calls can still be permitted.
4. **Set Content & Privacy Restrictions —** Screen Time → Content & Privacy Restrictions → toggle on. This unlocks all the content controls below. Nothing is restricted until you turn this on.

Tip: The Screen Time passcode is the single most important step. Without it, a child can go to Settings → Screen Time → Turn Off Screen Time and undo everything — unless you've set a passcode you haven't used elsewhere.

Key Settings — What Parents Can Control

DOWNTIME & APP LIMITS

- Screen Time → Downtime → set hours the device locks (school, bedtime).
- App Limits → Add Limit → select Social Networking or Games → set daily time.
- Always Allowed → remove any apps you don't want accessible during Downtime.
- Weekly Screen Time reports arrive automatically — review together, not in secret.
- Downtime works better for under-13s. For teens, App Limits per category (2hrs Social Networking) is often a more proportionate approach.

CONTENT & PRIVACY RESTRICTIONS

- Content Restrictions → Web Content → Limit Adult Websites (auto-filter) or Allowed Websites Only (whitelist).
- Content Restrictions → Apps → set maximum age rating (e.g. 12+).
- Content Restrictions → Explicit Language → Don't Allow (limits text and dictation).
- Content Restrictions → Music, Podcasts & News → Explicit → Off.
- Web Content filters only apply to Safari. If your child uses Chrome or another browser, block it via Allowed Apps settings.

IN-APP PURCHASES

- Content & Privacy → iTunes & App Store Purchases → In-App Purchases → Don't Allow.
- Installing Apps → Don't Allow (every install requires your Apple ID).
- Require Password → Always (even free downloads need Apple ID approval).

COMMUNICATION LIMITS

- Screen Time → Communication Limits → During Screen Time → Contacts Only.
- During Downtime → set to Specific Contacts or No One.
- Settings → Messages → Filter Unknown Senders → On (unknown numbers go to a separate tab).
- Communication Limits apply to Apple apps (Phone, Message, FaceTime) only. For Instagram, Snapchat, WhatsApp and Discord — see the CSG platform guides earlier in this handbook.

COMMUNICATION SAFETY (IOS 17+)

- Settings → Screen Time → Communication Safety → verify it is active (on by default for under-18s in a Family Sharing group).
- Detects nudity in photos sent or received in Messages and blurs it automatically.
- Child is prompted to contact a trusted adult — no images are sent to Apple or parents.
- Communication Safety is on by default for under-18s in a Family Sharing group. If your child's account is set up outside Family Sharing, verify it is active manually and without sharing images.

LOCATION SHARING

- Set up Family Sharing: Settings → your name → Family Sharing → Add Member.
- Child's device → Find My → Share My Location → select parent's Apple ID.
- Settings → Privacy & Security → Location Services → set location access to Never for risky apps.
- Talk to your child before enabling location sharing. Children who know they're located are more likely to speak up if something feels wrong, not less.

Conversation Starters

Can you show me your three favourite apps and what you do on them?

Has anyone ever messaged you who you didn't know? What did you do?

Do you ever feel like you spend too long on your phone? What does that feel like?

If you saw something upsetting online, would you know what to do?

I'm going to set up some Screen Time settings — can we look at them together?

Red Flags to Watch For

Turning the phone face-down or closing apps quickly when you walk past.

Taking the phone to the bathroom or staying up late to use it in secret.

Becoming upset, anxious or withdrawn after being on their phone.

New contacts on “online friends” they won't talk about.

Unexplained App Store charges or new apps you didn't approve.

Asking for unusual amounts of privacy or getting angry if you glance at the screen.

Quick Check — Things to Do Right Now

- Turn on Screen Time and set a passcode different from the device passcode.
- Set Downtime hours for bedtime and school — only Always Allowed apps work during Downtime.
- Turn on Content & Privacy Restrictions and set Web Content to Limit Adult Websites.
- Set Communication Limits to Contacts Only and turn on Filter Unknown Senders.
- Verify Communication Safety is on by default for under-18s in Family Sharing, check manually if not.
- Block in-app purchases and set App Store downloads to require approval.

Screen Time is a tool, not a solution. The most important thing you can do is keep the conversation open and make it easy for your child to come to you. If your child shows you something worrying, your reaction in that moment decides whether they come to you again.

Where to Get Help

Childline: 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk — free, confidential support for young people 24/7 · CEOP (Child Exploitation): ceop.police.uk — report online grooming or sexual exploitation · Internet Matters: internetmatters.org — guides and tools for parents on online safety

SCREEN TIME & DEVICE OVERUSE

Screens are part of life. Balance is the key. Too much screen time can affect sleep, mood, learning and wellbeing. You can help. Here's what parents need to know.

70%
of 8-17 year olds spend too much time on screens
NHS, 2023

4.5 hrs
average daily screen time for teens
Ofcom, 2023

2x
higher risk of poor sleep with high screen use
Sleep Foundation, 2022

1 in 3
parents say screen time causes daily family conflict
Parent Zone, 2023

By the Numbers

53%
of kids say they sometimes or always feel addicted to their screens
Common Sense Media, 2022

62%
of teens get notifications even during homework time
Pew Research, 2022

20%
get less than the recommended 8–10 hours of sleep on school nights
CDC, 2022

45%
of parents say screen time impacts their child's mood or behaviour
Parent Zone, 2023

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's not just about time.** Content, context and your child's personality all matter.
2. **Balance beats zero.** Screens aren't the enemy. Overuse is.
3. **Small changes, big difference.** Routines and limits help more than lectures.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Screen Time / Digital Wellbeing — see usage and set limits.
- Downtime / Focus Mode — block apps and alerts at bedtime or school hours.
- App Limits — set daily time limits for apps and categories.
- Content Restrictions — block inappropriate content and mature websites.
- Family Link / Family Sharing — manage devices and approve apps and purchases.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set daily limits that work for your family.
- Block during homework, meals and bedtime.
- Turn off unnecessary notifications.
- Review apps your child uses most.
- Check privacy and content settings.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Check your child's screen time.** Look at usage together.
2. **Set clear boundaries.** Agree on times, places and limits.
3. **Create screen-free zones.** Bedrooms, meals and family time.
4. **Plan fun offline time.** Sports, hobbies, reading, friends.
5. **Lead by example.** Your habits shape theirs.
6. **Review and adjust.** What works today may change. Keep talking.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Poor Sleep**, Blue light and late-night use can disrupt sleep.
- **Mental Health Impact**, Overuse is linked to anxiety, low mood and body image issues.
- **Attention Problems**, Constant stimulation can reduce focus and patience.
- **Safety Risks**, More screen time can mean more exposure to online risks.
- **Less Physical Activity**, Too much sitting affects fitness and overall health.
- **Academic Impact**, It can reduce study time and lower achievement.

The 10-Minute Conversation

How do you feel after a lot of screen time?

What apps or games do you enjoy most? Why?

What's getting in the way of balance?

What limits or routines would help you?

Partner with your child. It works better.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Take a break. Reset together.
- Reduce screen time gradually.
- Focus on sleep, routine and offline time.
- Praise small wins.

Report & Seek Help

- Talk to your GP if mood, sleep or behaviour are affected.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Seek help for persistent problems.

SHARENTING (POSTING YOUR KIDS ONLINE)

We love sharing our kids' milestones. It's natural. But once it's online, you lose control. Here's what parents need to know.

81%
of parents share photos of their kids online
Pew Research, 2023

1 in 3
parents worry about their child's digital privacy
Pew Research, 2023

73%
of teens say it's hard to control what parents post about them
Common Sense, 2022

Forever
once it's online, it can be copied, shared and saved forever

By the Numbers

72%
of parents don't realise how long content stays online
Microsoft, 2021

57%
of 10-17 year olds say it's too easy to share personal info online
Pew Research, 2023

39%
of parents have shared something they later wished they hadn't
Kaspersky, 2021

81%
of people say they review their privacy settings rarely or never
Pew Research, 2023

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's not just a photo.** It's your child's digital footprint.
2. **Your child has rights too.** They can't consent when they're young.
3. **What's cute today could be embarrassing tomorrow.** Think now, protect their future.

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Privacy Settings — limit who can see your posts.
- Audience Controls — Friends only, custom lists.
- Tag Review — approve tags before they appear.
- Location Controls — turn off location sharing.
- Account Privacy — make accounts private.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set accounts to private.
- Limit who can comment or message.
- Turn off location tagging.
- Don't share personal details or schedules.
- Review tags and remove old posts if needed.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Pause.** Do I need to share this?
2. **Check.** Would I be happy if my child posted this about me?
3. **Protect.** Remove names, dates, locations if possible.
4. **Ask.** Get your child's opinion as they get older.
5. **Adjust.** Use privacy settings.
6. **Review.** Look back and clean up old posts.

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Loss of Privacy**, Photos and details can be shared or saved forever.
- **Identity Risks**, Personal info can be used by others.
- **Safety Risks**, Strangers may track or contact your child.
- **Future Impact**, Old posts can affect education, jobs and reputation.
- **Embarrassment**, Kids may feel upset or lose trust.
- **Not Your Audience**, What you share may not be what others want to see.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What's OK to share about you?

What would you rather we keep private?

How would you feel if someone shared that about you?

Can we agree to check in together as you get older?

Listen. Respect. Include them in the decision.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Don't panic.
- Talk to your child.
- Remove the content.
- Save screenshots or links.
- Review privacy settings.

Report & Seek Help

- Report to the platform.
- Contact school if needed.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.

APPLE WATCH PARENTAL CONTROLS

Apple Watch can help kids stay connected, safe and independent. But it's still a connected device with communication, location sharing and access to apps. Here's what parents need to know.

Varies
no UK minimum age, but managed by a parent

Stay Connected
calls, texts, Walkie-Talkie & FaceTime (audio)

Location Sharing
see location in the Find My app (when enabled)

Apps, Music & Health
access to apps, music and health tracking features

What Parents Need to Understand

1. **It's a powerful communication tool.** Kids can make calls, send texts, use Walkie-Talkie and FaceTime (audio).
2. **You'll need a cellular model.** Apple Watch For Your Kids (Family Setup) only works on GPS + Cellular models (Series 6, SE or later, watchOS 7+). GPS-only watches cannot use Family Setup.
3. **Location features add safety.** You can share location with your child and they can share theirs (if you allow it).

Safety Features & Settings

WHAT EXISTS

- Family Setup — manage the watch for kids without an iPhone.
- Schooltime — limit distractions during school hours.
- Screen Time — set time limits for apps and device use.
- Location Sharing — share location with your child in the Find My app.
- Content & Privacy Restrictions — block apps, content and explicit material.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Review Privacy Settings — check what your child can share and with whom.
- Set Up Schooltime — add schedules and allow only what's needed.
- Adjust Screen Time Limits — set daily limits and downtime.
- Check App Access — review and approve apps and purchases.
- Enable Content Restrictions — limit mature content and in-app purchases.

Step-by-Step Safety Guide

1. **Set up with Family Setup.** From your iPhone.
2. **Add your child's Apple ID.** Or create one together.
3. **Configure location sharing.** In the Find My app.
4. **Set Schooltime rules and schedules.**
5. **Turn on Content & Privacy Restrictions.**
6. **Talk together about safe use and boundaries.**

The Risks Worth Knowing

- **Unexpected Contact**, Calls and messages can come from unknown numbers.
- **Location Misuse**, Location sharing can reveal routines or locations.
- **Inappropriate Content**, Apps, messages or web content may not be suitable.
- **Distractions**, Notifications and apps can affect focus and sleep.
- **In-App Purchases**, Apps and subscriptions can lead to unwanted costs.
- **Loss or Theft**, Personal data and payment cards could be a risk.

The 10-Minute Conversation

What do you like most about your Apple Watch?

Who do you talk to or message?

What apps do you use the most?

Who can call or message you on your watch?

What would you do if someone made you feel uncomfortable?

Open conversations build trust. Kids are more likely to ask for help when they know they won't get into trouble.

Stay Calm & Gather Evidence

- Take screenshots if needed.
- Note the time, date and what happened.
- Stop further contact if it feels unsafe.

Report & Seek Help

- Use Apple's reporting tools in Messages or FaceTime.
- Block unwanted contacts.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact police if there is immediate risk.

WHY KIDS DON'T TELL PARENTS (AND HOW TO FIX IT)

Kids aren't trying to hide things to upset you. They're trying to protect themselves. Here's what parents need to know.

2 in 3
teens say they don't tell their parents about things online
Common Sense, 2022

57%
of teens say they're afraid their parents will overreact
Pew Research, 2023

1 in 2
teens say it's easier to deal with problems online by themselves
Nielsen, 2023

But...
teens who feel close to their parents are 2x more likely to ask for help
Pew Research, 2023

Why Kids Don't Tell Parents

- **Fear of Reaction** — They worry you'll overreact, get angry, lecture or take away their devices.
- **Don't Want to Disappoint** — They don't want to let you down or feel like they've broken your trust.
- **Embarrassment** — It feels awkward or humiliating to talk about what happened.
- **Don't Think It's a Big Deal** — They think it's normal, not dangerous or something they can handle.
- **Worry About Losing Privileges** — They think you'll take away their phone, apps or online access.
- **Don't Know How to Say It** — They don't always have the words or know how to start the conversation.

What Kids Wish Parents Knew

- We want your help, but we're scared of how you'll react.
- We need you to listen before you advise or fix.
- We make mistakes. We need guidance, not shame.
- We want to feel safe talking to you about anything.
- We need you to trust that we'll come to you.

Signs a Child Might Be Struggling Online

- Secretive about devices or mood changes.
- Suddenly avoids certain apps or friends.
- Anxiety, sadness, anger or withdrawal.
- Trouble sleeping or changes in appetite.
- Less interest in activities they used to enjoy.

How to Fix It: Build a Relationship They Can Count On

1. **Create a Safe Space —** stay calm. Your reaction matters most. Let them know they won't get in trouble for coming to you. Say: “I'm always here to help, no matter what.”
2. **Listen First —** let them talk without interrupting. Show you understand before offering advice. Say: “Thanks for telling me. That takes courage.”
3. **Keep the Conversation Going —** talk regularly, not just when there's a problem. Ask open questions. Show interest in their world online. Say: “Tell me about...”
4. **Respect Their Privacy (Age-Appropriate) —** trust helps them come to you. Give them space, but stay involved. Set boundaries together.
5. **Focus on Solutions, Not Punishments —** work together to solve the problem. Guide, don't control. Praise honesty, not perfection.
6. **Be Their Teammate —** side with them, not against them. Work as a team to keep them safe. Say: “We'll figure this out together.”

What to Say (and What to Avoid)

SAY THIS

- “Thank you for telling me.”
- “I'm proud of you for coming to me.”
- “Let's figure this out together.”
- “I believe you.”
- “You're not in trouble.”

AVOID THIS

- “Why were you so stupid?”
- “I told you so.”
- “Give me your phone.”
- “You're grounded!”
- “You can't be trusted.”

Opening Conversations (Try These)

- “What's been the best (or worst) thing online this week?”
- “Is there anything online that makes you feel uncomfortable?”
- “How do you handle issues online with friends?”
- “If one of your friends had this problem, what would you tell them to do?”
- “What apps or games are you into right now?”
- “Is there anything I can do to support you better?”

What to Do If Something Bad Happens

1. **Stay calm —** your calm helps them open up.
2. **Listen & reassure —** let them share. Reassure them they did the right thing.
3. **Don't blame —** blame shuts down conversation. Support opens it up.
4. **Take action —** report, block, document and get help if needed.
5. **Review & learn —** talk about what happened and how to stay safer.
6. **Follow up —** check in later. Keep the conversation going.

Trust is built in the small moments. The more your child feels heard, the more likely they are to come to you.

Daily Habits That Build Trust

- Spend quality time together.
- Show interest in their life.
- Celebrate small wins.
- Apologise when needed.
- Laugh & have fun together.
- Be consistent. Be present. Be the safe place they can always come back to.

If You're Not Sure, Get Help

You don't have to handle it alone.

- Talk to your child's school.
- Contact a trusted adult.
- Use helplines and support services.
- For serious concerns, contact police.
- Asking for help is one of the best things you can do.

__PAGEBREAK__

THE "EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT" PROBLEM

Kids want what their friends have. It's normal. But “everyone else” isn't always a good reason. Here's what parents need to know.

73%
of teens feel pressure to keep up with friends online
Pew Research, 2022

2x
teens are more likely to ask for tech when friends have it
Common Sense, 2022

45%
of teens say they feel left out when they can't join in
Nielsen, 2023

1 in 3
teens say seeing others with new tech makes them want it more
Piper Sandler, 2023

Why This Happens

- **The Need to Belong** — Kids don't want to feel left out. Belonging is powerful — especially in middle school and high school.
- **Social Pressure Is Real** — When friends have something, it can feel like you need it too to fit in.
- **Comparison Hurts** — Constant comparing leads to stress, low self-esteem and “not enough” thinking.
- **It's Not Just About the Stuff** — It's about status, access, games, features, and being part of the conversation.
- **Marketing Makes It Worse** — Ads, influencers and trends push the idea that new = better (and you need it).
- **Missing Out Is Real** — Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) can push kids to say “yes” to unsafe choices.

What Kids Are Really Thinking

- “If I don't have it, they'll think I'm weird.”
- “Everyone else has it.”
- “They'll stop inviting me.”
- “It's how we hang out.”
- “What if I miss something important?”
- “It's not fair.”

What Parents Need to Understand

- It's not just about the device or app. It's about connection and acceptance.
- Saying “no” without a plan can make your child feel more isolated.
- Kids need boundaries — and support — to handle social pressure.
- You can teach them confidence, critical thinking and digital balance.

Smart Ways to Respond

1. **Acknowledge their feelings.** “I get why this matters to you.”
2. **Ask questions.** “What do you think having it will help you do?”
3. **Set clear boundaries.** Based on safety, age and values.
4. **Offer options.** “Let's find another way to stay connected.”
5. **Teach delay, not denial.** Help them wait without shame.
6. **Build real-world confidence.** Skills > status.

Talk About It: Try These Conversation Starters

- What do you think makes everyone want the same things?
- How do you feel when your friends have something you don't?
- What's most important to you — fitting in or being yourself?
- How can we handle social pressure together?
- What can you do when you feel left out?

Help Them Build Inner Strength

- Remind them what makes them unique.
- Celebrate effort, not “stuff”.
- Encourage activities that build real confidence.
- Model contentment and balance.
- Teach them that “enough” is a superpower.

Say This Instead

- “You are enough.”
- “People who matter don't mind.”
- “You don't need the latest to be your best.”
- “You make your own story.”

Parents: You're Not Alone

- You don't have to say yes to every request.
- It's okay to be different from other families.
- Your calm, confident leadership helps them navigate peer pressure.
- Keep the lines of communication open — always.

The bottom line: friendship matters. Your values matter more. Help your child choose connection and confidence over comparison and keeping up.

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If a child needs support right now: **Childline — 0800 1111 | childline.org.uk** — free, confidential, 24 hours a day.